Given that the boilers were broken, the next question was, where to dock the steamer—Colombo, where it lay, or Bombay? SSNCo's Colombo Agent C. Thumbayya preferred Bombay though there seems to have been some disagreement among the directors managing the show. Writing to VOC (in prison), he stated,

> I proposed to have the *Gallia* taken to Bombay and the suggestion was approved of by the Sec[retar]y. I mean to send her soon but some of the people at the Head Office have apparently not fallen in with my views. However, I hope to prevail, as this step will show the Co[mpan]y a great saving. As you know, Bombay is a better place than Colombo in many respects as we have a chance of fitting her up there with a second-hand boiler and making use of her, if we are unable to dispose of the vessel.[154]

At the same time, SSNCo's Bombay Agents Soonderdas Dhurumsey & Co. too were writing to VOC that negotiations were going on with J. Mackintosh and Company, London, for changing the boilers.[155] While SSNCo's Colombo Agent was suggesting second-hand boilers, the Bombay counterparts preferred new ones. Meanwhile, M.D. Devadoss Pillai, the company's director who was then in London preparing to appear for the bar, was negotiating with Mackintosh for new boilers. 'As the season was slack', he had got a good price and that Mackintosh was ready to ship them before the end of the year. Though he hoped that money would not be a problem, he was concerned that S.D. Krishna Aiyangar had not responded to his letter asking for his final instructions in the matter.[156]

But with little progress being made on this front, the *Gallia* weighed down the company. *The Hindu*'s Ceylon correspondent rued that such failings reflected badly on the company's reputation and cried in exasperation, 'Can't a way be found to get rid of the *Gallia*?'[157] Barely six months after its triumphant arrival in April 1907, the *Gallia* had now come to such a pass.

The phantom of the quality of the steamers would never rest, coming back to haunt the company and its partisans. Rivals, and those distinctly unsympathetic to VOC and his Swadeshi politics, often blamed the ships for SSNCo's collapse. In the proceedings of the Indian Mercantile Marine